

Viswanathan Anand

Chess grandmaster 1969

LIGHTNING KID

Every sport needs an icon. It was the super cool champion who took chess out of its snobby confines and made it a mass movement which has seen the birth of several prodigies. None though is quite as gifted.

■ By Dibyendu Barua

I remember my first meeting with Viswanathan Anand. It was 1983 and chess wasn't that big a game then. It was something that children pursued when they were inspired by their parents. Adults played it, but only when they wanted to play a "serious game". The National Junior Association championship was going on in Delhi. In strode a thin, lean fellow in a cap and looked around determinedly. That is when I saw his chess game for the first time. He was fast. That was the word that came to my mind. He played his game quickly and precisely, so much so that all of us there christened him the Lightning Kid. His speed showed in his body language. He would never sit and play but would constantly move around.

It was a deep first impression. I remember everyone's surprise when he played and the techniques that he displayed, even then. It was in 1992 that I met him again. And that was when I played against him. He was not undefeated in the early 1980s or, perhaps, till 1986. I played him and even won sometimes. But in 1992, I realised that his game had progressed to another level, just like he himself had. From a Lightning Kid he had become a much calmer Anand, a true Grandmaster. I think the change came in 1986 and was consolidated in 1987 when he

became world junior champion.

Anand had an innate talent for being a Grandmaster. One can put in 14 hours of work everyday and become good, but to become a player par excellence one has to be a prodigy. Which Anand was. It was Anand who demolished the Russian supremacy, which earlier only Bobby Fischer could. It was he, who questioned the supremacy of a Garry Kasparov, an Anatoly Karpov and a Vladimir Kramnik. That was especially remarkable as India was not a country which encouraged chess at that time.

For any field to come into the limelight, it needs an icon, a master attached to it. Like Donald Bradman outside and Kapil Dev here who made cricket highly popular, Anand brought chess forward, into the view of millions abroad and more importantly at home. In India, it meant that a new game was discovered and it shows in the many young people following the game now. It is his single-handed achievement that resulted in chess becoming what it is today.

Anand the man is equally astonishing. Astonishing in the fact that he is very unlike most famous Grandmasters I know. When I met him in Norway in the World Junior Championship, he had lost a match, was quite frustrated and nearly moved to tears. In that perturbed state he threw his keys against the



Q: How many times has he won the Chess Oscar?

A: Four, in 1997, 1998, 2003 and 2004

Q: At what age was he awarded the Padma Shri?

A: At 18

Q: In which year did he become the first Indian to win the World Junior Chess Championship?

A: 1987

Q: What do his friends call him?

A: Vishy

Q: Which IT company has Anand as its brand ambassador?

A: NIIT

BANDEEP SINGH